Social media is thus more than just a broadcasting tool for IOs—it constitutes a strategic platform. IOs develop long-term communication plans, assess their impact, and refine their messaging to improve public perceptions (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2018a). Doing so can have a meaningful effect on perceptions of IO legitimacy (Dellmuth 2018; Tallberg and Zürn 2019; Dellmuth et al. 2021; Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023), bolstering IOs' ability to achieve their mandates. Indeed, legitimacy is crucial if IOs are to maintain member-state participation and secure funding in areas like trade and development (Keohane 1984; Milner and Tingley 2012; Morse and Keohane 2014).

Many IOs have actively sought domestic buy-in to bolster their legitimacy. The EU, for example, has long attempted to "reconnect with the European public," reshaping its messaging to address democratic deficits and public concerns about accountability (Michailidou 2008; Barisione and Michailidou 2017b). Similarly, international courts and other IOs have employed democratic narratives to emphasize fairness and inclusivity, hoping to resonate with diverse audiences (Dingwerth, Schmidtke, and Weise 2020; Lenz and Söderbaum 2023).

Scholarship suggests that these initiatives have achieved mixed success (Blair, Marty, and Roessler 2022; Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023). This is, in part, because IOs may seem disingenuous when tooting their own horns on social media (see Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023). Endorsements of IOs from domestic politicians or NGOs, who often appear less biased, can be more helpful. The EU's social media strategies exemplify the mixed outcomes of such efforts. While social media has empowered critics, it has also affirmed a sense of European unity and mitigated perceptions of democratic deficits (Barisione and Michailidou 2017a).

We posit that IOs use social media not just to disseminate information but also to strategically counter populist critiques. By portraying themselves as relatable and highlighting their positive impacts on ordinary people, IOs aim to enhance public trust and legitimacy. In the following sections, we explore the effectiveness of these strategies, examining how IOs leverage social media against the backdrop of populist resistance.